

Survey Wording Experiment Classroom Run Kit

TOK Cognitive Science Activity Bank • Human Sciences • 25-30 min

Category	Human Sciences	Time	25-30 min
Difficulty	Medium	ID	survey-wording-experiment

Big idea: Measuring beliefs can alter the result.

One-Minute Teacher Brief

Students see how the act of measurement can shape human-science data.

Student Prompt

Inspect Survey Wording Experiment Stimulus A. Record one first claim, the evidence you used, your confidence, and what would make you revise.

Concrete Stimulus Packet

Survey Wording Experiment Stimulus A	Student-facing stimulus 1: Two versions of the same question using 'support' versus 'allow'. Predict how people will respond, then identify the wording, context, incentive, or role that could change the result.	Students inspect this exact card first and commit to a claim before hearing anyone else.
Survey Wording Experiment Stimulus B	Student-facing stimulus 2: A neutral, loaded, and leading survey item on the same issue. Predict how people will respond, then identify the wording, context, incentive, or role that could change the result.	Use this for comparison, a second round, or a partner challenge.
Survey Wording Experiment Reveal / Twist	Student-facing stimulus 3: A class comparison chart showing how wording shifts results. Predict how people will respond, then identify the wording, context, incentive, or role that could change the result.	Teacher reveal: connect the changed response to the big idea — Measuring beliefs can alter the result.

Actual Lesson Questions

#	Question for students	Teacher key / cue
1	After inspecting Survey Wording Experiment Stimulus A, what is your first knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: look for a clear claim, not just a description.
2	Which exact detail from Survey Wording Experiment Stimulus A did you use as evidence?	Teacher cue: students should name visible words, data, source features, method features, or contextual clues.
3	What did you infer beyond the evidence?	Teacher cue: this is where assumptions, framing, models, or perspective usually appear.
4	How confident are you: 50%, 60%, 70%, 80%, 90%, or 100%?	Teacher cue: confidence is data for the debrief, not a grade.
5	What missing information would most improve the knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: push for method, source, context, comparison, or definitions.
6	Can surveys measure beliefs objectively?	Teacher cue: students should move from the classroom example to a general TOK issue.

Student Task

Use the stimulus cards to complete the observation/inference/evidence/confidence grid, then answer one TOK knowledge question connected to Human Sciences.

Teacher Key / Reveal

The key move is not the “right answer”; it is the moment students see how measuring beliefs can alter the result.

- Strong response: separates observation from inference.
- Strong response: names a method, source, model, language choice, context, or perspective.
- Strong response: revises confidence when new evidence or a new criterion appears.
- Weak response: gives only opinion or says “it depends” without criteria.

Student Instructions

- Work silently for the first response so you can notice your own starting point.
- Record one knowledge claim, the evidence behind it, and your confidence level.
- After the reveal or comparison, update your claim in a different colour or column.
- Use the debrief to answer: Can surveys measure beliefs objectively?

Setup Checklist

- Prepare a starter stimulus using: Two versions of the same question using 'support' versus 'allow'.
- Print or project the student response grid before the activity begins.
- Plan a private first-response moment before any group discussion.

Example Stimuli or Materials

- Two versions of the same question using 'support' versus 'allow'.
- A neutral, loaded, and leading survey item on the same issue.
- A class comparison chart showing how wording shifts results.

Resources To Use

- Resource pack: <resources/survey-wording-experiment/index.html>
- Card deck CSV: <resources/survey-wording-experiment/cards.csv>
- Visual prompt: <resources/survey-wording-experiment/visual-prompt.svg>
- Printable student worksheet with observation, inference, evidence, and confidence columns.
- Teacher notes with setup checklist, sample facilitation language, misconceptions, and assessment look-fors.
- Classroom run kit with prompt cards, example stimuli, and debrief moves.
- PowerPoint deck with a student-facing sequence for running the activity.

Run Sequence

1. Half the class receives: "Should students be allowed to use AI to support learning?"
2. The other half receives: "Should students be allowed to use AI to complete schoolwork?"
3. Compare results.
4. Students redesign the question to reduce bias.

Debrief Moves

- Knowledge question: Can surveys measure beliefs objectively?
- How does wording shape data?
- Are human sciences less certain, or differently certain?

Teacher Quick Script

- Write your first judgement before we discuss it; the first answer is useful evidence.
- Separate what you noticed from what you inferred.
- What would make this knowledge claim more reliable?

Exit Ticket

- One thing I first treated as evidence was...
- My confidence changed because...
- A better knowledge question I can now ask is...